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William Godwin on Democracy: The Time-Regime of Political Thought in the Age of Revolutions

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William Godwin is predominantly recognized as a theoretical anarchist who envisioned a tranquil anarchy wherein no government was deemed necessary. Equally emphasized in academic literature is Godwin's unwavering advocacy for gradualism and pacifism as a transition mechanism toward the ideal society—a strategy criticized by some as inadequate or naive in realizing this ideal. Scholars of Godwin have identified a contradiction within his thought on this basis. This article, however, argues that this contradiction dissolves when we shift the focus to what could be termed the “time-regime” of Godwin's politics: the business of the present differed from the business of the future, even as the present served as road to the future. Viewed through this lens of time-regime, the remarkable significance of democracy in Godwin's scheme of anarchy becomes evident. Accordingly, this article seeks to analyze his concept of democracy within the backdrop of the French revolutionary decade.

You know perhaps already that I am of that odious class of men called democrats,
and of that class I shall for ever continue

William Wordsworth, May 1794.¹

Introduction

The significance of William Godwin as a political philosopher in the late eighteenth century is beyond question. Against him, on the one hand, one may locate a copious amount of spite in such hostile characterizations as the one by Thomas James Mathias, who claimed that “Mr. Godwin is at best but a mongrel and an exotick ... grafted upon the stock of Condorcet and the French rabble ... with all his desolating, unfounded, and silly opinions on all trades, professions, and occupations, wholly subversive of the

¹ William Wordsworth to William Mathews, 23 May 1794, in *The Letters of William Wordsworth: A New Selection*, ed. Alan G. Hill (Oxford, 1984), 11–14, at 12.

order of society.”² William Hazlitt, on the other hand, affirmed the intellectual weight of Godwin, who had “secured to himself the triumphs and the mortifications of an extreme notoriety and of a sort of posthumous fame,” by remarking that “Tom Paine was considered for the time as a Tom Fool to him; Paley an old woman; Edmund Burke a flashy sophist.” Even if Godwin’s opinions had been “over-charged,” Hazlitt argued, it did not follow that they had been “altogether groundless”: Godwin had “blazed as a sun in the firmament of reputation” and had “carried with him all the most sanguine and fearless understandings of his time.”³

Two centuries later, a more or less common picture of Godwin emerges from the historical, political, and literary studies devoted to him. Godwin was, according to this picture, a “rationalist” in his view of human nature and perfectibility, with an unfailing faith in “reason.”⁴ He was a “dissenter” who regarded “traditional” Christianity as a potential threat to “individual autonomy, integrity and self-confidence” but did not hold all religious aspects of human nature irredeemably guilty of hindering perfectibility.⁵ He was also a “utilitarian” in his mode of value judgment and an “anarchist” par excellence in his political ideal.⁶ Godwin is recognized as a fascinating theoretical anarchist,⁷ and Colin Ward asserts with confidence that Godwin is the first in line of the forefathers of “the anarchist tradition.”⁸ For Mark Philp he is “one of the earliest advocates of anarchism” with a perfectibilist faith in the primacy of private judgment, and Derry Novak places Godwin’s *Enquiry Concerning Political Justice and Its Influence on Morals and Happiness* (1793) at the origin of “a systematic elaboration and formulation of modern anarchist thought.”⁹

While there is no doubt about Godwin’s credentials as a key figure in the history of anarchism, what is often noted with interest is his staunch insistence on gradualism and pacifism as the transition mechanism toward his visionary society, even at the price of his friendship with John Thelwall and other radicals of the London Corresponding Society.¹⁰ Godwin put forth the idea of a peaceful anarchy, in which no government was

²Thomas James Mathias, *The Pursuits of Literature: A Satirical Poem in Four Dialogues*, 7th edn (London, 1798), 371–5.

³William Hazlitt, *The Spirit of the Age: or Contemporary Portraits* (London, 1825), 31–3.

⁴David Collings, “The Romance of the Impossible: William Godwin in the Empty Place of Reason,” *ELH* 70/3 (2003), 847–74.

⁵Rowland Weston, “William Godwin’s Religious Sense,” *Journal for Eighteenth-Century Studies* 32/3 (2009), 407–23.

⁶John P. Clark, *The Philosophical Anarchism of William Godwin* (Princeton, 1977); Robert Lamb, “Was William Godwin a Utilitarian?”, *Journal of the History of Ideas* 70/1 (2009), 119–41.

⁷Clark, *Philosophical Anarchism*; Peter Marshall, *Demanding the Impossible: A History of Anarchism* (Oakland, 2010); Marshall, *William Godwin: Philosopher, Novelist, Revolutionary* (Oakland, 2017); Richard Gough Thomas, *William Godwin: A Political Life* (London, 2019).

⁸Colin Ward, *Anarchism: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford, 2004), 3.

⁹Derry Novak, “The Place of Anarchism in the History of Political Thought,” *Review of Politics* 20/3 (1958), 307–29, at 320; Mark Philp, *Godwin’s Political Justice* (London, 1986), 1.

¹⁰Mark Crosby, “The Voice of Flattery vs Sober Truth: William Godwin, Thomas Erskine and the 1792 Trial of Thomas Paine for Sedition,” *Review of English Studies* 62/253 (2011), 90–112. See, however, Mark Philp, “Candour, Courage, and the Calculation of Consequences in Godwin’s 1790s,” in Eliza O’Brien, Helen Stark, and Beatrice Turner, eds., *New Approaches to William Godwin: Forms, Fears, Futures* (Cham, 2021), 81–101.

needed because the society was divided into batches small enough to make its members feel the weight of their neighbors' opinion almost as enforcing as penal laws. This was thought to be possible on the condition that the people reach a level of intellectual enlightenment where their reason can be trusted to correctly perceive the "truth" and control the passions accordingly. In Godwin's view such a state of society could only be attained "by slow degrees."¹¹ Since revolutions were "the produce of passions, not of sober and tranquil reason," they had to be rejected at all costs: "as it is only in a gradual manner that the public can be instructed, a violent explosion in the community is by no means the most likely to happen as the result of instruction."¹²

Isaac Kramnick criticizes Godwin in this context for holding the view that the diffusion of enlightenment by education and discussion was the sole tolerable road to the ideal future in which government (necessarily an "evil" for Godwin) is abolished. Kramnick is not wide off the mark when he points out that Godwin considered all contemporary reform movements apt to mislead the multitude away from the "correct" path to progress.¹³ Godwin was clearly targeting Thelwall and the LCS when he warned of the dangers of political passions and demagoguery in *Considerations on Lord Grenville's and Mr. Pitt's Bills* (1795). Andrew McCann remarks that Godwin was at this point "precariously close to the anti-Jacobin propaganda that portrayed Richard Price, Joseph Priestley, Thomas Paine, Thomas Spence, Thelwall, and Godwin himself as the emissaries of a fraudulent print-capitalism peddling words and ideas before a public of ill-educated labourers easily deceived by shrewd marketing strategies."¹⁴ On McCann's account there is a glaring contradiction in Godwin's theory of government and opinion:

The opposition between unmediated public opinion and the coercive effects of political and legal institutions is, however, one that Godwin can only maintain so long as the public sphere is understood in abstract terms ... Whenever he discusses what were the actual institutions of counterhegemonic public interaction—working class organizations like the London Corresponding Society, or popular presses producing cheap editions of libertarian political tracts—the public itself becomes a pathological variant of this ideal, precisely because of the extent to which it is mediated through both popular oration (which Godwin understands as demagogic) and print media (which he understands as manipulative).¹⁵

¹¹William Godwin, *Political and Philosophical Writings of William Godwin*, 7 vols., vol. 4: *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice: Variants*, ed. Mark Philp (London, 1993), 119.

¹²*Ibid.*, 120; Clark, *Philosophical Anarchism*, 223–47; Ian Ward, "A Love of Justice: The Legal and Political Thought of William Godwin," *Journal of Legal History* 25/1 (2004), 1–30; Gregory Claeys, *The French Revolution Debate in Britain: The Origins of Modern Politics* (Houndmills, 2007), 118–37.

¹³Isaac Kramnick, "On Anarchism and the Real World: William Godwin and Radical England," *American Political Science Review* 66/1 (1972), 114–28.

¹⁴William Godwin, *Political and Philosophical Writings of William Godwin*, 7 vols., vol. 2, *Political Writings II*, ed. Mark Philp (London, 1993), 125–62; Andrew McCann, *Cultural Politics in the 1790s: Literature, Radicalism and the Public Sphere* (Houndmills, 1999), 66.

¹⁵McCann, *Cultural Politics in the 1790s*, 61.

But this apparent contradiction in Godwin identified by McCann dissolves when we relocate the focus to what may be termed the “time-regime” of his political philosophy: the business of the present differed from the business of the future, even as the present served as road to the future. The “ideal” of an enlightened and “unmediated public opinion” belonged to the future while the “actual” public belonged to the present. When this time-regime is taken seriously, *pace* McCann, the public of the present is no longer a “pathological variant” of an “ideal.” The time-regime found in the thoughts of Godwin’s contemporaries operated in a historical framework that regarded the recent past as evidence of society’s capacity for progress driven by the Enlightenment. This framework envisioned a distant future in which the human mind and social institutions would have advanced to such an extent that most of the seemingly insurmountable barriers to progress in the present would have been overcome. This time-regime did not necessarily entail a concrete transition mechanism from one state to another, apart from enlightenment in manners and the sciences, an idea that worked as the *philosophes*’ trump card. Thus, identifying a time-regime in a given thinker’s work does not in itself promise a novel revelation of their precise strategies for addressing contemporary crises or advancing from one stage to the next within the time-regime. Nonetheless, by delineating the cross-temporal horizon of a thought, a fresh focus on the time-regime allows us to grasp the broader spectrum of a thinker’s intellectual outlook, avoiding the pitfall of asking essentialist questions about their ideological positions.

This time-regime, with its conception of multiple pasts and futures at varying temporal distances from the present, formed the framework for Condorcet’s celebrated *Sketch for a Historical Picture of the Progress of the Human Mind* (1795).¹⁶ Godwin, an avid reader of Condorcet,¹⁷ became an unintended companion in criticism as both were targeted by Thomas Robert Malthus in his *An Essay on the Principle of Population ... with Remarks on the Speculations of Mr. Godwin, M. Condorcet, and Other Writers* (1798).¹⁸ The case of Jacques Pierre Brissot, whom Godwin also read with interest,¹⁹ demonstrates that Godwin’s ideal of a society of enlightened people living happily in liberty without government was not unique to himself in the age of revolutions. Brissot declared in the preface to his *New Travels in the United States* (first published in 1791) that “liberty exists in reverse proportion to the extent of governmental powers.” He proceeded, in an extreme rendition of the argument, to state, “Coercive laws and liberty cannot exist together. A free people detest any form of repression. But then, if coercive means are not used, who will execute the laws? Reason and the force of moral

¹⁶Marie Jean Antoine Nicolas de Caritat, Marquis de Condorcet, *Esquisse d'un tableau historique des progrès de l'esprit humain* (1795). See also Condorcet, *Tableau historique des progrès de l'esprit humain: Projets, esquisses, fragments et notes*, ed. Jean-Pierre Schandeler and Pierre Crépel (Paris, 2004).

¹⁷William Godwin’s diary, at <http://godwindiary.bodleian.ox.ac.uk>, 22 Oct. 1791, 27 Dec. 1791, 30 Dec. 1791, 19 Sept. 1792, 20 Nov. 1793, 21 Nov. 1793, 26 Nov. 1793, 19 June 1795, 13 July 1795, 14 July 1795, 15 July 1795, 16 July 1795, 25 July 1795, 26 July 1795, and 27 July 1795.

¹⁸Thomas Robert Malthus, *An Essay on the Principle of Population, as It Affects the Future Improvement of Society, with Remarks on the Speculations of Mr. Godwin, M. Condorcet, and Other Writers* (London, 1798).

¹⁹William Godwin’s diary, 1 Feb. 1794, 21 Feb. 1794, 22 Feb. 1794, 23 Feb. 1794, 24 Feb. 1794, 1 March 1794, 3 March 1794, 5 March 1794, and 2 March 1796.

principles.” Brissot was adamant that “a people without government” may well be happy “if we can suppose a people all of whom are virtuous.” Though he conceded that such a society did not exist at the time, he stressed that it was “not a utopian dream” since its feasibility was proven by the “American Quakers.” For him this meant that revolutionary France could “go far” and one day reach the state of liberty without government by striving to “become more enlightened,” with a view to the future when “morals and customs can take the place of laws completely and even make them unnecessary.”²⁰ This was a statement that went even further than Paine’s claim that, “the more perfect civilization is, the less occasion has it for government, because the more does it regulate its own affairs, and govern itself.”²¹ Brissot’s point was that the French people “will gradually free themselves of political misconceptions ... for the essence of reason and of enlightened liberty is endless progress and the universal triumph of truth over error and of principle over prejudice.”²² It was an instance of Godwinian philosophical anarchism *avant la lettre*. After Godwin, we also witness Jean-Baptiste Say declare in 1815 in a letter addressed to Jeremy Bentham that if books like his own *Catechism of Political Economy* “were circulated in all countries,” reason and enlightenment “would gradually make their way” in time, after which it would be “seen whether governments are really such a necessary part of society; and if they will then be able to make nations pay so dearly for benefits which they do not confer.” Even though Say believed that such time would not come “till we are gone,” his time-regime enabled him to tell Bentham that “our labour will not be lost.”²³

There is yet an even more crucial point to be made from the time-regime perspective: if Godwin’s anarchy was an ultra-long-term end to be reached by the ultra-gradual means of education and discussion, then “democracy” was for him the form of government that would in the meantime provide the best of opportunities for the amelioration of human reason and happiness. The implied transition mechanism was that this development of reason accelerated by a democratic political environment could eventually bring about a social condition amenable to anarchy. Political agency was needed to establish and maintain democracy, which was already a difficult task, and all the more so to avoid excessive violence in the process. John Clark thus argues against Kramnick that Godwin did not profess “a complete rejection of political activity.” On this account Godwin’s philosophy had a pragmatic side which led him to defend “a type of decentralized democracy as the least evil form of government” and show “support for the Whig Party” with some consistency.²⁴ But even as commentators have noted

²⁰Jacques Pierre Brissot, *New Travels in the United States of America, 1788*, ed. Durand Echeverria, trans. Durand Echeverria and Mara Soceanu Vamos (Cambridge, MA, 1964), 14–15, 23.

²¹Thomas Paine, *Rights of Man, Part II: Combining Principle and Practice*, 9th edn (London, 1792), 10.

²²Brissot, *New Travels*, 23.

²³Jean-Baptiste Say to Jeremy Bentham, 2 Aug. 1815, *Electronic Enlightenment Scholarly Edition of Correspondence* (henceforth EESEC), at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/bentjeOU0080491a1c> (accessed 1 September 2025). For Say’s revolutionary republicanism see Minchul Kim, “Jean-Baptiste Say and the Political Economy of Republican Utopia in Revolutionary France,” *History: The Journal of the Historical Association* (2025), at <https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-229X.70053>.

²⁴John P. Clark, “On Anarchism in an Unreal World: Kramnick’s View of Godwin and the Anarchists,” *American Political Science Review* 69/1 (1975), 162–7, at 162.

Godwin's favourable view of democracy in comparison to other forms of government—especially Clark, who stressed that Godwin wished “to establish extremely limited, decentralized and direct democracy in the place of the powerful, centralized and indirect forms”—none has so far conducted a detailed analysis of his idea of democracy with a focus on his time-regime and in the context of eighteenth-century and revolutionary European thought.²⁵ This reservation applies as well to other recent studies on Godwin, such as those looking at his thoughts on property,²⁶ his novels and children's books,²⁷ his history of the seventeenth-century English Revolution,²⁸ his relationship with Mary Wollstonecraft,²⁹ or his connection to John Thelwall and their strategies for radical politics.³⁰

As a supplement to current literature, this article attempts to analyze Godwin's idea of democracy in context. This rereading of Godwin as a democrat will place him more firmly within the context of the French revolutionary decade and provide the ground for an account of his political thought in a way richer than what may be suggested by labels such as “anarchist,” “moralist,” “individualist,” or “utilitarian.” It will delve into how widely and why “democracy” was denounced in Godwin's time, and then place him among various contemporary views on democracy—for and against—to suggest an understanding of what past and contemporary arguments he was reacting to and what his responses might have meant. From this viewpoint, this article stands to demonstrate that the point made by Gregory Claeys—that Godwin rejected

²⁵ Clark, *Philosophical Anarchism*, 179–202; Ian Ward, “The Abode of Moral Truth: William Godwin's *Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*,” *ARSP: Archiv für Rechts und Sozialphilosophie/Archives for Philosophy of Law and Social Philosophy* 89/3 (2003), 349–71, at 368–9; Ward, “A Love of Justice,” 12–13.

²⁶ Clark, *Philosophical Anarchism*, 248–73; Robert Lamb, “For and against Ownership: William Godwin's Theory of Property,” *Review of Politics* 71/2 (2009), 275–302; Chris Pierson, “The Reluctant Pirate: Godwin, Justice, and Property,” *Journal of the History of Ideas* 71/4 (2010), 569–91.

²⁷ Margaret Fearn, “William Godwin and the ‘Wilds of Literature,’” *British Journal of Educational Studies* 29/3 (1981), 247–57; Daniela Garofalo, “A Left-Handed Way: Modern Masters in William Godwin's *Caleb Williams*,” *European Romantic Review* 17/2 (2006), 237–44; Pamela Clemit, “Readers Respond to Godwin: Romantic Republicanism in Letters,” *European Romantic Review* 20/5 (2009), 699–707; Anna Maria Jones, “‘What Should Make Thee Inaccessible to My Fury?’ Gothic Self-Possession, Revenge, and the Doctrine of Necessity in William Godwin's *Caleb Williams*,” *European Romantic Review* 22/2 (2011), 137–54; Cathy Collett, “Every Child Left Behind: *St. Leon* and William Godwin's Immortal Future,” *European Romantic Review* 25/3 (2014), 327–36; John-Erik Hansson, “William Godwin, Romantic-Era Historiography and the Political Cultures of Infancy,” in Martina Domines Veliki and Cian Duffy, eds., *Romanticism and the Cultures of Infancy* (Houndmills, 2020), 183–201.

²⁸ John Morrow, “Republicanism and Public Virtue: William Godwin's *History of the Commonwealth of England*,” *Historical Journal* 34/3 (1991), 645–64; Timothy Campbell, “‘The Business of War’: William Godwin, Enmity, and Historical Representation,” *ELH* 76/2 (2009), 343–69; Porscha Fermanis, “William Godwin's *History of the Commonwealth* and the Psychology of Individual History,” *Review of English Studies* 61/252 (2010), 773–800.

²⁹ Amy Rambow, “‘Come Kick Me’: Godwin's *Memoirs* and the Posthumous Infamy of Mary Wollstonecraft,” *Keats-Shelley Review* 13/1 (1999), 24–57; Julie A. Carlson, *England's First Family of Writers: Mary Wollstonecraft, William Godwin, Mary Shelley* (Baltimore, 2007).

³⁰ Kenneth R. Johnston, “Usual and Unusual Suspects: John Thelwall, William Godwin and Pitt's Reign of Terror,” in Steve Poole, ed., *John Thelwall: Radical Romantic and Acquitted Felon* (London, 2009), 25–37; John-Erik Hansson, “The Genre of Radical Thought and the Practices of Equality: The Trajectories of William Godwin and John Thelwall in the mid-1790s,” *History of European Ideas* 43/7 (2017), 776–90.

“representative forms of democracy” against the “widespread and powerful” tide of his time and opted instead for ancient republicanism³¹—should be revised by placing Godwin within the terms of the eighteenth-century debate on democracy, representation, and virtue. In fact, the idea of “representative democracy” in its 1790s meaning was neither widespread nor powerful. Godwin nonetheless opted for it in ways that only a minority group of radical French democrats would later do in the latter half of the revolutionary decade, as a conscious choice made in rejection of both ancient republicanism and modern commercial republicanism after the death of Robespierre.³²

Obloquy of democracy in the eighteenth century

A discussion of Godwin’s take on democracy may well be situated within the broader context of the prevailing perspectives on that form of politics in the eighteenth century and the French revolutionary decade, during which his *Enquiry Concerning Political Justice* was published. In the early 1790s Godwin was not riding a huge wave of developing “democratic” thought, which cannot be said to have tangibly existed. He was rather articulating a minority position that appears to have neither influenced, nor been influenced by, the revolutionary democrats across the Channel in any direct way, the latter’s thought having been elaborated well after the publication of *Enquiry*. Rarely mentioned in practical politics prior to the 1790s, the notion of “democracy” was loaded with many a great burden inherited from the past, namely that it led to disorder, civil war, military government, and decline.³³ Both before and during the 1790s, the term mainly referred to classical Athens—including Sparta or Rome from time to time—and its principal working mechanism was considered to be sortition instead of election.³⁴ Democracy was often deemed tumultuous and ferocious, and most of all unfit for the moderns, who had to devote their lives to labor, unlike the ancients, who had been able to rely on slave labor for production and thus to focus on “public” affairs.³⁵ Hardly any “modern” in Europe, not even the radicals of the French Revolution, subscribed to

³¹Gregory Claeys, “William Godwin’s Critique of Democracy and Republicanism and Its Sources,” *History of European Ideas* 7/3 (1986), 253–69, at 254.

³²Bernard Gainot, “La notion de ‘démocratie représentative’: Le legs néo-jacobin de 1799,” in Michel Vovelle, ed., *L’image de la Révolution française* (Paris, 1989), 523–9; Pierre Serna, “Comment être démocrate et constitutionnel en 1797?,” *Annales historiques de la Révolution française* 308 (1997), 199–219; Minchul Kim, “The Political Economy of Democracy in the French Revolution: Publicola Chaussard and the Democrats under the Directory,” *History of Political Thought* 43/4 (2022), 729–58.

³³Pierre Rosanvallon, “L’histoire du mot démocratie à l’époque moderne,” in Marcel Gauchet, Pierre Manent, and Pierre Rosanvallon, eds., *Situations de la démocratie* (Paris, 1993), 11–29; Mark Philp, “Talking about Democracy: Britain in the 1790s,” in Joanna Innes and Mark Philp, eds., *Re-imagining Democracy in the Age of Revolutions: America, France, Britain, Ireland 1750–1850* (Oxford, 2013), 100–13; James Kloppenberg, *Toward Democracy: The Struggle for Self-Rule in European and American Thought* (Oxford, 2016), 1.

³⁴Hugo Bonin, *“At the Sound of the New Word Spoken”: Le mot “démocratie” en Grande-Bretagne, 1770–1920* (Rennes, 2024), 31–5.

³⁵André Samuel Michel, “Réflexions du traducteur sur la présente situation de la France,” in Edward Wortley Montagu, *De la naissance et de la chute des anciennes républiques* (par Édouard-Worthley de Montague), trans. André Samuel Michel (Paris, 1793), 373–84.

this idea of “democracy” as a practicable norm.³⁶ Democratic liberty was considered short-lived because of the tendency of popular assemblies to invite (out of gratitude or ignorance or both) demagogues or ambitious generals to establish a tyrannical or military government.³⁷

Signifying a form of government in direct opposition to “representative government,” the word “democracy” referred to a political society of an allegedly mad and ferocious populace ruling over the wise and honest few.³⁸ Dutch thinkers such as Johan Luzac, Elie Luzac, and Johan Meerman put forth unswerving criticisms of “democracy” both ancient and modern.³⁹ It was argued in France that grave inconveniences resulted from the “excess” necessarily generated by democracies.⁴⁰ Some contemporaries of Jean-Jacques Rousseau considered him a democrat and “a veritable incendiary” who preached the principles of “the absolute democracy, which is the dissolution of all good police.”⁴¹ But it is now a truism that neither Rousseau nor Voltaire—both were of keen interest to Godwin—recommended democracy for modern states.⁴² If the passions and ignorance of the “populace” provided the ultimate reason for the rejection of democracy, another key problem lay in the perceived difficulty of attaining and sustaining its essential trait: equality. Jean-Louis de Lolme claimed in his *Constitution of England*, a work praised and deemed important in England and America in the period of the American and the French revolutions,⁴³ that democracy was unattainable because history—particularly Roman and Florentine—proved that laws enacted to “restore that equality which is the essence of a democratical government were always found impracticable.”⁴⁴ During the French revolutionary decade the term “democracy” was often employed—even by many republicans deemed “radical” in their own times—to stress how important it was for republics to avoid turning into democracies.⁴⁵ There were exceptions to this rule, among which a notable case was Thomas

³⁶R. R. Palmer, “Notes on the Use of the Word ‘Democracy’ 1789–1799,” *Political Science Quarterly* 68/2 (1953), 203–26; Wilfried Nippel, *Ancient and Modern Democracy: Two Concepts of Liberty?*, trans. Keith Tribe (Cambridge, 2016), 105–203.

³⁷Iain McDaniel, *Adam Ferguson in the Scottish Enlightenment: The Roman Past and Europe’s Future* (Cambridge, MA, 2013), 5–6, 45.

³⁸Bernard Manin, *The Principles of Representative Government* (Cambridge, 1997); Minchul Kim, “Theories of Representative Government against Democracy during the French Revolution,” *The Historian* 84/4 (2022), 565–85.

³⁹Wyger Velema, “Against Democracy: Dutch Eighteenth-Century Critics of Ancient and Modern Popular Government,” in Wyger Velema and Arthur Weststeijn, eds., *Ancient Models in the Early Modern Republican Imagination* (Leiden, 2018), 189–213.

⁴⁰Jean-Pierre-François de Ripert, Marquis de Monclar to Jacques-François Deluc, late Dec. 1763–early Jan. 1764, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/rousjeVF0180268a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

⁴¹Jean-Pierre Crommelin to Pierre Lullin, 3 Jan. 1765, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/rousjeVF0230016a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

⁴²William Godwin’s diary: Rousseau appears in twenty-seven entries between 20 Nov. 1789 and 28 Nov. 1826, and Voltaire in thirty-seven entries between 22 Nov. 1791 and 25 June 1832.

⁴³David Lieberman, “Introduction,” in Jean-Louis de Lolme, *The Constitution of England; Or, an Account of the English Government* (ed. 1784), ed. David Lieberman (Indianapolis, 2007), ix–xxi, at ix.

⁴⁴De Lolme, *The Constitution of England*, 68.

⁴⁵Minchul Kim, “Republicanism in the Age of Commerce and Revolutions: Barère’s Reading of Montesquieu,” *French History* 30/3 (2016), 354–75, at 373; Kim, “Volney and the French Revolution,” *Journal*

Paine, with whom Godwin discussed “monarchy, Tooke, Johnson, Voltaire, pursuits & religion” over a dinner table.⁴⁶ More importantly, there existed a small group of French democrats who tried to combine “representation” and “democracy” to formulate a novel political arrangement under the banner of “representative democracy.” But they never succeeded anywhere in winning over the political majority before the Brumaire.⁴⁷

If we move to the British context closer to Godwin, even though the term “democrat” became “a badge of identity” for a handful of English radicals in the 1790s, as seen in the cases of Sir St John Mildmay, John Gale Jones, and Amelia Alderson, the overall intensity of vilification of democracy was not any weaker.⁴⁸ In *Reflections on the Rise and Fall of the Antient Republics* (1759), Edward Wortley Montagu expressed the commonplace view that Athens had been “truly democratick, and so much convulsed by those civil dissensions, which are the inevitable consequences of that kind of government.”⁴⁹ His verdict was representative of the eighteenth-century English perception of classical Athens:

The history of Athens abounds with instances of the levity and inconstancy of that unsteady people. For how frequently do we find their best and ablest citizens imprisoned or sentenced to banishment by the ostracism, in honour of whom the same people had just before erected statues ... This evil was the natural consequence of that capital error in Solon's polity, when he entrusted the supreme power to the giddy and fluctuating populace. A defect which (as I observed before) was the great leading cause of the loss of that liberty which they had so licentiously abused.⁵⁰

In another instance, democracy was defined as “referring determinations, either legislative or executive, to the people at large,” and subsequently dubbed “the worst form

of the History of Ideas 79/2 (2018), 221–42, at 236; Kim, “Condorcet and the Viability of Democracy in Modern Republics, 1789–1794,” *European History Quarterly* 49/2 (2019), 179–202, at 182.

⁴⁶William Godwin's diary, 13 Nov. 1791.

⁴⁷Bernard Gainot, 1799, *un nouveau Jacobinisme? La démocratie représentative, une alternative à brumaire* (Paris, 2001); Raymonde Monnier, “‘Démocratie représentative’ ou ‘république démocratique’: De la querelle des mots (République) à la querelle des anciens et des modernes,” *Annales historiques de la Révolution française* 325 (2001), 1–21; Christopher Hobson, “Revolution, Representation and the Foundations of Modern Democracy,” *European Journal of Political Theory* 7/4 (2008), 449–71; Minchul Kim, “Pierre-Antoine Antonelle and Representative Democracy in the French Revolution,” *History of European Ideas* 44/3 (2018), 344–69; Kim, “Démocratiser le gouvernement représentatif? La pensée politique d'Antoine Français de Nantes sous le Directoire,” *Annales historiques de la Révolution française* 396 (2019), 71–93.

⁴⁸Kyriacos Demetriou, “In Defence of the British Constitution: Theoretical Implications of the Debate over Athenian Democracy in Britain, 1770–1850,” *History of Political Thought* 17/2 (1996), 280–97; Karen E. Whedbee, “The Tyranny of Athens: Representations of Rhetorical Democracy in Eighteenth-Century Britain,” *Rhetoric Society Quarterly* 33/4 (2003), 65–85; Philp, “Talking about Democracy,” 108–9, 113.

⁴⁹Edward Wortley Montagu, *Reflections on the Rise and Fall of the Ancient Republics*, ed. David Womersley (Indianapolis, 2015), 47.

⁵⁰*Ibid.*, 54.

of government imaginable.”⁵¹ Edmund Burke, whose “prominence ... in Godwin’s reading” is noted by Mark Philp,⁵² claimed,

in the forty years of my observation, as much injustice and tyranny has been practised in a few months by a French democracy, as by all the arbitrary monarchs in Europe ... This democracy begins very ill; and I feel no security that what has been rapacious and bloody in its commencement, in its final settlement will be mild and protecting. They cannot, indeed, in future rob so much, because they have left little that can be taken.⁵³

This was written in early 1790, when hardly any revolutionary in Paris dreamed of establishing a republic, not to mention a democracy, in the Kingdom of France. The term “French democracy” was widely used to denote reprovingly both the French monarchy before 1792 and the Republic afterwards, to warn the Britons against “the establishment of a fanatical democracy just at its door,” to borrow Burke’s words.⁵⁴ By January 1792 Burke considered France to be enslaved under the rule of Jacobins, who, by means of “the bribing of an immense body of soldiers, taken from the lowest of the people, to an universal revolt against their officers, who were the whole body of the country gentlemen, and the landed interest of the nation,” proceeded to “set themselves up as a kind of democratic military, governed and directed by their own clubs and committees.” It was his view that “avowed admirers of the French democracy” permeated England like germs.⁵⁵ Adam Ferguson also believed that, since the early days of the French Revolution, “the French are too busy translating their monarchy into a democracy.”⁵⁶ On the other side of the table, Richard Price tried to shore up the reputation of himself and his fellow “Protestant Dissenters” by quoting from his own speech that he knew “not one individual among them who would not tremble at the thought of changing into a Democracy our mixed form of government.”⁵⁷ Even as “the iniquitous conduct of Russia and Prussia with regard to Poland reconcile again men’s minds to democracy,” remarked David Gray in his letter to Jeremy Bentham discussing the second partition of Poland during the Terror, “the daily enormities committed in France

⁵¹ Edmund Pendleton to Carter Braxton, 12 May 1776, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/pendedVH0010177a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

⁵² Mark Philp, “Godwin, Thelwall, and the Means of Progress,” in Robert Maniquis and Victoria Myers, eds., *Godwinian Moments: From the Enlightenment to Romanticism* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2011), 59–82, at 66.

⁵³ Edmund Burke to Captain Thomas Mercer, 26 Feb. 1790, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/burkedOU0010284a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

⁵⁴ Edmund Burke to Richard Burke, 26 Sept. 1791, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/burkedOU0010317a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

⁵⁵ Edmund Burke to William Weddell, 31 Jan. 1792, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/burkedOU0010325a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

⁵⁶ Adam Ferguson to Sir John Macpherson, 1st Baronet Macpherson of Calcutta and Lauriston, 31 July 1790, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/fergadPC0020340a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

⁵⁷ Richard Price to William Smith, 1 March 1790, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/pricriDU0030272a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

tend to excite disgust in respect to popular governments.”⁵⁸ It is important to note that when Godwin discussed the example of classical Athens in *Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, he was challenging those views of democracy commonly held in the British and the wider European contexts. However, before turning to that part of the story we could benefit from clarifying what “democracy” did *not* mean to Godwin.

Democracy without social contract or legislative sovereignty of the people

In the late eighteenth century, various objections were made to the mainstream rejection of democracy as barbarous, ferocious, and obsolete. One of the most famous among them in the anglophone world was Part I of *Rights of Man* (1791), which was Thomas Paine’s refutation of Burke’s *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790). Paine put forth the notion that a modern kind of democratic republic, founded upon the theory of social contract and popular sovereignty and buttressed by the mechanism of election and representation, was superior to the hereditary and constitutional monarchy.⁵⁹ Paine’s view of democracy was a compound of multiple eighteenth-century radical perspectives which also influenced the Girondin proposal of a democratic constitution in February 1793 largely written by Nicolas de Caritat, Marquis de Condorcet. Paine, as a member of the French National Convention at the time, signed the Girondin proposal along with Charles Jean Marie Barbaroux, Bertrand Barère, Condorcet, Armand Gensonné, Jérôme Pétion, Emmanuel Joseph Sieyès, and Pierre Victurnien Vergniaud. Although the Convention was eventually moved by the speeches of Montagnards like Maximilien Robespierre and Louis Antoine de Saint-Just to reject the Girondin proposal and adopt a revised version of it, Condorcet’s version became (in)famous thereafter as a radically democratic constitution.⁶⁰

Godwin, unlike the revolutionaries in France, had no truck with the notion of original social contract. Rejection of social contract was not uncommon in eighteenth-century thought, especially among the advocates of “natural sociability.” Theorists of sociability contended that contractualists such as Thomas Hobbes and Rousseau underrated mankind’s potentials for perfectibility as a group, a society, and a species, by making the postulation that men were born solitary and hostile to each other or that the state of society was a degenerate form of human existence compared to the state of nature.⁶¹ The language of natural sociability elaborated in the works of Hugo Grotius

⁵⁸David Gray to Jeremy Bentham, 15 Jan. 1794, *EESEC*, at <https://doi.org/10.13051/ee:doc/bentjeOU0050005a1c> (accessed 1 Sept. 2025).

⁵⁹Edmund Burke, *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (London, 1790); Thomas Paine, *Rights of Man: Being an Answer to Mr. Burke’s Attack on the French Revolution* (London, 1791); Gregory Claeys, *Thomas Paine: Social and Political Thought* (Boston, 1989); Carine Lounissi, *La pensée politique de Paine en contexte: théorie et pratique* (Paris, 2012).

⁶⁰Marcel Dorigny, “Du projet girondin de février 1793 au texte constitutionnel du 24 juin 1793,” in Roger Bourderon, ed., *L’an I et l’apprentissage de la démocratie* (Paris, 1995), 107–18; Giorgio La Neve, “Thomas Paine’s Influence on the Girondin Constitutional Project of 1793,” *Parliaments, Estates and Representation* 38/2 (2018), 192–204; Kim, “Condorcet and the Viability of Democracy,” 191–2.

⁶¹Béla Kapossy, “The Sociable Patriot: Isaak Iselin’s Protestant Reading of Jean-Jacques Rousseau,” *History of European Ideas* 27/2 (2001), 153–70; Nigel DeSouza, “Language, Reason, and Sociability: Herder’s Critique of Rousseau,” *Intellectual History Review* 22/2 (2012), 221–40; Eva Piirimäe, “Philosophy, Sociability and

and Samuel von Pufendorf, combined with the rise of the discourse of “commercial society,”⁶² came to the fore in eighteenth-century moral and political discourse.⁶³ Speculations on an original contract were redundant, according to this view, since men were naturally born to form societies. After George Turnbull’s declaration that “it cannot be asserted that there is nothing social in our nature, without denying the most evident truths,”⁶⁴ Adam Ferguson laughed at Hobbes for having “made the state of nature to consist in perpetual wars, kindled by competition for dominion and interest, where every individual had a separate quarrel with his kind, and where the presence of a fellow-creature was the signal of battle.” He also criticized Rousseau for having “represented mankind in their first condition, as possessed of mere animal sensibility, without any exercise of the faculties that render them superior to the brutes, without any political union, without any means of explaining their sentiments, and even without possessing any of the apprehensions and passions which the voice and the gesture are so well fitted to express.” Ferguson dubbed their theories of social contract “fruitless inquiries” and “wild suppositions.”⁶⁵

Godwin believed in “perfectibility” and affirmed that the “most desirable condition of the human species is a state of society.”⁶⁶ For him the notion of a social contract exercising a binding effect upon posterity—*de jure* or *de facto*—was therefore most unfortunate when human perfectibility was considered, for “little will be gained for the cause of equality and justice if our ancestors, at the first institution of government ... could barter away the understandings and independence of all that came after them.”⁶⁷ Some aspects of his rejection of social contract were different from those of the supporters of natural sociability: here he was concerned less with the contractualists’ negative verdict on the prospect of perfectibility or with the defects of their “conjectural” tendencies than with the three logical fallacies that he identified within the contract theory itself. First, if contracts were to be renewed in time, it was difficult to ascertain precisely how long the intervals between them should be. It was even more difficult to know the source of obligation to adhere to the contract during that interval, especially for those

Modern Patriotism: Young Herder between Rousseau and Abbt,” *History of European Ideas* 41/5 (2015), 640–61, at 640–41.

⁶²Istvan Hont, “The Language of Sociability and Commerce: Samuel Pufendorf and the Theoretical Foundations of the ‘Four-Stages’ Theory,” in Hont, *Jealousy of Trade: International Competition and the Nation-State in Historical Perspective* (Cambridge, MA, 2005), 159–84; Hans W. Blom, “Sociability and Hugo Grotius,” *History of European Ideas* 41/5 (2015), 589–604; Heikki Haara, “Pufendorf on Passions and Sociability,” *Journal of the History of Ideas* 77/3 (2016), 423–44.

⁶³Andrew Hamilton, “Benjamin Vaughan on Commerce and International Harmony in the Eighteenth Century,” in Scott Breuninger and David Burrow, eds., *Sociability and Cosmopolitanism: Social Bonds on the Fringes of the Enlightenment* (London, 2012), 101–20; Mark Nixon, “At Home in a World of Fictions: Commercial Sociability in Montesquieu’s *Persian Letters*,” in *ibid.*, 59–80; Robert Wokler, “Rousseau’s Pufendorf: Natural Law and the Foundations of Commercial Society,” in Bryan Garsten, ed., *Rousseau, the Age of Enlightenment, and Their Legacies* (Princeton, 2012), 88–112.

⁶⁴George Turnbull, *The Principles of Moral Philosophy: An Enquiry Into the Wise and Good Government of the Moral World* (London, 1740), 194.

⁶⁵Adam Ferguson, *An Essay on the History of Civil Society*, 3rd edn (London, 1768), 2–3.

⁶⁶Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 9.

⁶⁷William Godwin, *Political and Philosophical Writings of William Godwin*, 7 vols., vol. 3, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, ed. Mark Philp (London, 1993), 83.

who had not given explicit consent to the preceding contract (for reasons such as the contract being one “into which my father entered before I was born”).⁶⁸

Second, since no social contract had been signed by each and every citizen, “the nature of the consent” was often construed as “acquiescence.” In 1748 David Hume discussed with sarcasm the opinion that “by living under the dominion of a prince, which one might leave, every individual has given a *tacit* consent to his authority, and promised him obedience.” For Hume the theory of consent was “erroneous” and “repugnant to the common sentiments of mankind, and to the practice and opinion of all nations and all ages.”⁶⁹ Godwin, too, fulminated against the theory of tacit consent: “upon this hypothesis every government that is quietly submitted to is a lawful government, whether it be the usurpation of Cromwell, or the tyranny of Caligula.” The theory of tacit consent, on this account, was unjust to “the peasant and the artisan” who in fact lived in a certain country simply because they did not practically “have it in their power to transport themselves to another.”⁷⁰

Third, in the face of the complexity of social life, an act of consent to a code could clarify neither the duration of that consent nor the rigidity of its application to specific cases.⁷¹ A particularly acute problem for Godwin was that it seemed impossible to justify the imposition of laws enacted by one part of the people on another who had refused to consent to them. If Rousseau had argued this problem away by forcing everybody to submit to the “general will” expressed in the form of the majority after counting the votes, Godwin pointed out that such an easy resolution did not hold well with the Genevan’s own theory of the inalienability of sovereignty:

If a tacit consent be not sufficient, still less can I be deemed to have consented to a measure upon which I put an express negative. This immediately follows from the observations of Rousseau. If the people, or the individuals of whom the people is constituted, cannot delegate their authority to a representative, neither can any individual delegate his authority to a majority, in an assembly of which he is himself a member ... no man can transfer to another the keeping of his conscience and the judging of his duties ... No consent of ours can divest us of our moral capacity.⁷²

In Godwin’s conclusion, Rousseau was wrong to think that a government could “derive its authority from an original contract.”⁷³ Since “reason” developed *through* time and could change the formerly expressed will for the better, according excessive weight to the will of a certain point in time could prevent individual perfection from fostering social improvement. The focus had to be firmly placed on the time-regime of the development of individual reason and its translation into social perfection. In the same vein Godwin disputed the central tenet of the theory of popular sovereignty, namely that the

⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, 83.

⁶⁹ David Hume, *Essays Moral, Political and Literary*, ed. Eugene F. Miller (Indianapolis, 1985), 475, original emphasis, 486.

⁷⁰ Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 83–4.

⁷¹ *Ibid.*, 84–5.

⁷² *Ibid.*, 86.

⁷³ *Ibid.*

legislative power was the ultimate mark of sovereignty and that the sovereign people had the exclusive authority to exercise it.⁷⁴ For him the question of who possessed the authority to make laws was misleading, since legislation was “not an affair of human competence”:

Reason is the only legislator, and her decrees are irrevocable and uniform. The functions of society extend, not to the making, but the interpreting of law; it cannot decree, it can only declare that, which the nature of things has already decreed, and the propriety of which irresistibly flows from the circumstances of the case ... All political power strictly speaking is executive ... To the public support of justice therefore the authority of the community extends. But no sooner does it wander in the smallest degree from the line of justice than its proper authority is at an end, it stands upon a level with the obscurest individual, and every man is bound to resist its decisions.⁷⁵

The last line might have sounded like too outspoken an endorsement of political resistance, for Godwin removed it in subsequent editions of *Enquiry* (1796 and 1798).⁷⁶ “True” legal authority would emanate solely from “immutable reason,” which was “the true legislator.” Practical authority of the “community” was grounded only on “necessity” and was not the source of “real duty” by itself. Authority did not spring from consent but from truth.⁷⁷ Here he stood miles away from the theory of “legitimacy by consent” in that he preferred to regard the “immutable” rules of justice as inscribed in the “nature of things.”⁷⁸ His thought was also at a distance from the account of God-given laws already written down in the Gospels and sacred histories, in that he believed that human reason was as yet insufficiently developed to grasp those laws but potentially perfectible in his time-regime to the extent of being able to discover the “true” laws, so that coercive authority would be rendered redundant and fade away

⁷⁴Regarding this aspect of popular sovereignty, Pavlos Eleftheriadis has recently put forth the argument that the coexistence of sovereignty and law is “impossible.” Pavlos Eleftheriadis, “Law and Sovereignty,” *Law and Philosophy* 29/5 (2010), 535–69.

⁷⁵Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 95–6.

⁷⁶Here I follow Mark Philp, who, while noting that the second and third editions of *Enquiry* were published in late 1795 and late 1797 respectively, chose to adhere to the convention of referring to them as the 1796 and 1798 editions. Philp, *Godwin's Political Justice*, 7–8. The 1796 edition read, “it may be submitted to from necessity; but its existence, as to the matter in question, is an uncompensated evil.” The 1798 edition became even less radical: “it may be submitted to by its subjects from necessity; from necessity it may be exercised, as an individual complies with his ill-informed conscience in default of an enlightened one; but it ought never to be confounded with the lessons of real duty, or the decisions of impartial truth.” Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice: Variants*, 108.

⁷⁷Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 95–6; Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice: Variants*, 108.

⁷⁸The tension between “will” and “truth” existed in Rousseau’s writings as well, though he thought himself to have reconciled them by positing the omniscience or infallibility of the “general will.” Melissa Schwartzberg, “Voting the General Will: Rousseau on Decision Rules,” *Political Theory* 36/3 (2008), 403–23; Christopher Bertram, “Rousseau’s Legacy in Two Conceptions of the General Will: Democratic and Transcendent,” *Review of Politics* 74/3 (2012), 403–19.

into nonexistence.⁷⁹ Thereby disposed of the theories of social contract and legislative sovereignty, Godwin's vision of "democracy" was at once similar to and different from that of many of his contemporaries. The next section is an analysis of what "democracy" meant to him from this perspective.

Democracy, representation, and the time-regime of perfectibility

Without reference to popular sovereignty or social contract, Godwin defined democracy as "a system of government according to which every member of society is considered as a man and nothing more ... every man is regarded as equal." However, this was not to deny the "degree of influence" which "talents and wealth ... will not fail to obtain," but to assure that no "positive institution" recognized such traits by conferring legal, political, or social privileges on them.⁸⁰

Godwin laid out the alleged "disadvantages that may seem the necessary result of democratical equality" before proceeding to refute those claims. On the surface, democracy was "wavering and inconstant," far away from the immutable truth and "every idea of political justice." It was argued that this negative dynamism was the result of the "ignorance and folly ... of the unwise," which always formed the majority and chose the "turbulent and crafty demagogue" as their leader. Liberty was therefore precarious in democracies. As people got "tired of hearing Aristides constantly called the Just," merit became "too frequently the victim of ignorance and envy."⁸¹ Before beginning his assault on the above view, Godwin presented a summary of what he thought to be the most serious implication of such a view on the future of mankind:

No form of government can be devised which does not partake of monarchy, aristocracy or democracy ... it would seem impossible that greater or more inveterate mischiefs can be inflicted on mankind, than those which are inflicted by [the two former]. If then democracy could by any arguments be brought down to a level with such monstrous institutions as [monarchy or aristocracy], in which there is neither integrity nor reason, our prospects of the future happiness of mankind would indeed be deplorable.⁸²

It should be noted here that Godwin neither discussed one of the most powerful and virulent criticisms laid on "democracy" by his contemporaries—that democracy led to military government and to the fall of liberty—nor endeavoured to reply to it. This is an aspect that could have weakened the import of his arguments, but what is significant at the moment is the salient presence of a time-regime in his discussion of democracy. Most importantly, since government could not be abolished overnight in the present state of enlightenment, *some* government had to be at work. It would be best for the development of human nature if *that* extant government fostered education

⁷⁹Richard Tuck, *Natural Rights Theories: Their Origin and Development* (Cambridge, 1979); Annabel S. Brett, *Changes of State: Nature and the Limits of the City in Early Modern Natural Law* (Princeton, 2011), 41–2.

⁸⁰Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 266.

⁸¹*Ibid.*, 266–7.

⁸²*Ibid.*, 267.

and enhanced reason through public discussion. But since monarchy and aristocracy were such terribly obscurantist forms of government, Godwin argued, an eternity of misery would follow unless man could place hope on “democracy” during the process of perfection prior to reaching the “auspicious period” that would finally witness the “dissolution of political government, of that brute engine, which has been the only perennial cause of the vices of mankind.”⁸³ Was democracy incurable and mankind doomed? Godwin’s reply was a firm negative: while democracy was widely regarded as “anarchy,” he boldly claimed that anarchy was, though “undoubtedly a horrible calamity ... less horrible than despotism”:

Anarchy is a short lived mischief, while despotism is all but immortal. It is unquestionably a dreadful remedy, for the people to yield to all their furious passions, till the spectacle of their effects gives strength to recovering reason: but, though it be a dreadful remedy, it is a sure one. No idea can be supposed, more pregnant with absurdity, than that of a whole people taking arms against each other till they are all exterminated. It is to despotism that anarchy is indebted for its sting. If despotism were not ever watchful for its prey, and mercilessly prepared to take advantage of the errors of mankind, this ferment, like so many others, being left to itself, would subside into an even, clear and delightful calm.⁸⁴

The argument above, a defense of democracy demonized as “anarchy” rather than a defense of what has come to be known as political or philosophical anarchy nowadays, was an extremely bold move closely resembling the statement made by Condorcet—whose writings permeate Godwin’s diary between 1791 and 1795—in early 1789 that despotism was the cause of “anarchy” or the “despotism of the populace.”⁸⁵ Roland Garrett can thus be given only partial credit for his claim that Godwin “explicitly rejected the disorder of ‘anarchy’ ... while not conceiv[ing] of himself as opposing ‘democracy.’”⁸⁶

On top of this, Godwin posited that even if democracy must be taken “with all the disadvantages that were ever annexed to it,” however incurable they may be, that form of government would still be “greatly preferable to the exclusive system” of monarchy and aristocracy. Though filled with “turbulence” and instances of “usurpations of Pisistratus and Pericles” and “monstrous ostracism,” the history of classical Athens still “exhibited a more illustrious and enviable spectacle than all the monarchies and aristocracies that ever existed.”⁸⁷ There had existed, albeit rarely, a minority view of Athens

⁸³ Ibid., 311.

⁸⁴ Ibid., 296.

⁸⁵ Marie Jean Antoine Nicolas de Caritat, Marquis de Condorcet, “Idées sur le despotisme à l’usage de ceux qui prononcent ce mot sans l’entendre (1789),” in *Oeuvres de Condorcet*, ed. Arthur Condorcet O’Connor and Dominique François Jean Arago (Paris, 1847), 145–73, at 161–3; William Godwin’s diary, 22 Oct. 1791, 27 Dec. 1791, 30 Dec. 1791, 19 Sept. 1792, 20 Nov. 1793, 21 Nov. 1793, 26 Nov. 1793, 19 June 1795, 13 July 1795, 14 July 1795, 15 July 1795, 16 July 1795, 25 July 1795, 26 July 1795, and 27 July 1795.

⁸⁶ Roland Garrett, “Anarchism or Political Democracy: The Case of William Godwin,” *Social Theory and Practice* 1/3 (1971), 111–20, at 111.

⁸⁷ Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 267–8.

as a “polite polis” earlier in the late seventeenth century and the early eighteenth,⁸⁸ and further into the 1760s Catharine Macaulay had argued in her devastating criticism of Hobbes that the Greeks, “from whom alone we can learn ancient prudence,” had “disdained” monarchy and “called all pretenders to it tyrants and usurpers.”⁸⁹ In a bolder sense, marvelling at the Athenians’ genius and fortitude, Godwin exclaimed, “shall we compare a people of such incredible achievements, such exquisite refinement, gay without insensibility and splendid without intemperance ... shall we compare this chosen seat of patriotism, independence, and generous virtue, with the torpid and selfish realms of monarchy and aristocracy?” While scholars insist on Godwin’s adherence to pacifism in the diffusion of enlightenment and subsequent reforms, particularly from the second edition of *Enquiry*, it needs to be stressed that in the first edition he was joining the band of radicals of Georgian England and revolutionary France by asserting that “all is not happiness that looks tranquillity.” Perfection did not stem from inaction: “better were a portion of turbulence and fluctuation, than that unwholesome calm which is a stranger to virtue.”⁹⁰

More importantly, Godwin argued, traditional and contemporary verdicts on democracy shared an “error,” namely that they took “mankind such as monarchy and aristocracy [had] made them.” Monarchy and aristocracy were “evils” precisely because they tended to “undermine the virtues and the understandings of their subjects” by encouraging “implicit faith, blind submission to authority, timid fear, a distrust of our powers, an inattention to our own importance and the good purposes we are able to effect.” It was “unreasonable” to extrapolate “men as they hereafter be made” from “men as we now find them”: here we witness one of the most crucial elements of Enlightenment philosophy, the time-regime of perfectibility.⁹¹ In contrast to the reprehensible effects of monarchy and aristocracy, Godwin affirmed, the universally reviled democracy in fact “restores to man a consciousness of his value, teaches him by the removal of authority and oppression to listen only to the dictates of reason, gives him confidence to treat all other men as his fellow beings.”⁹²

That democracy was best at fostering patriotic and courageous citizen soldiers was a commonplace among eighteenth-century intellectuals. There were disagreements, however, regarding the desirability of this feature in the modern world. For example, among the many participants in what is now called the “French Revolution debate

⁸⁸ Christine Zabel, “From Failed Republic to Polite Polis: Ancient Athens in Seventeenth- and Eighteenth-Century England,” in Wyger Velema and Arthur Weststeijn, eds., *Ancient Models in the Early Modern Republican Imagination* (Leiden, 2018), 131–56, at 139–51.

⁸⁹ Catharine Macaulay, *Loose Remarks on Certain Positions to Be Found in Mr. Hobbes’ Philosophical Rudiments of Government and Society*, 2nd edn (London, 1769), 10. Kramnick, “On Anarchism and the Real World”; Ward, “A Love of Justice”; McCann, *Cultural Politics in the 1790s*, 59–61; Philp, “Godwin, Thelwall, and the Means of Progress”; Jon Mee, “‘The Press and Danger of the Crowd’: Godwin, Thelwall, and the Counter-public Sphere,” in Robert Maniquis and Victoria Myers, eds., *Godwinian Moments: From the Enlightenment to Romanticism* (Toronto, 2011), 83–102.

⁹⁰ Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 268.

⁹¹ Ibid. See also Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice: Variants*, 243.

⁹² Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 268–9.

in Britain,”⁹³ Adam Ferguson was particularly worried that the Revolution had given birth to a dangerously expansionist military democracy and that European governments were facing the danger of undergoing the same “fatal revolution terminating in military government.”⁹⁴ Godwin, in contrast, claimed himself to be “one of the most ardent admirers of the French Revolution” and expressed “the highest hopes” for the future of “man imbued with the spirit of this revolution.”⁹⁵ Even though the claim was expressed in a letter addressed to the National Convention of France in 1793, there is not much reason to doubt the sincerity of his declaration; given the political climate in London at that time, he likely had more to lose than to gain by making such a statement.⁹⁶ Regarding democracy, Godwin was of the view that it was not only better than other forms of government at domestic politics and enlightenment but also superior to them in military defense of the state, because “the citizen of a democratical state, when he looks upon the miserable oppression and injustice that prevail in the countries around him, cannot but entertain an inexpressible esteem for the advantages he enjoys, and the most unalterable determination at all hazards to preserve them.”⁹⁷ Since happy and content people would not want to conquer their neighbors, he affirmed, democratic states would shun “the principle of offensive war.”⁹⁸

Democracy’s strength in patriotism could overcome what had often been regarded as its defect, namely that “it [could] not keep secrets” where they were necessary, such as in matters of war. Godwin’s direct response to this criticism was that the “trick of a mysterious carriage [was] the prolific parent of every vice.” This moralist censure of *arcana imperii* was an insufficient rebuttal in itself, but it pointed to the aforementioned intrepid patriotism of democratic armies.⁹⁹ Refusal of secrecy was in fact to serve a deeper purpose, as the pathway par excellence to perfection was strict honesty. Deception, be it individual or institutional (such as the benevolent yet condescending projects for civil religion), was incompatible with the growth of reason.¹⁰⁰ As has been noted by scholars of Godwin, it was key to his vision of future society that everybody should always “speak and act the truth” so that discussion and persuasion, as

⁹³Gregory Claeys, “The French Revolution Debate and British Political Thought,” *History of Political Thought* 11/1 (1990), 59–80; Claeys, *The French Revolution Debate in Britain: The Origins of Modern Politics* (Houndmills, 2007); Wil Verhoeven, *Americomania and the French Revolution Debate in Britain, 1789–1802* (Cambridge, 2013); Morgan Rooney, *The French Revolution Debate and the British Novel, 1790–1814: The Struggle for History’s Authority* (Lanham, 2013).

⁹⁴McDaniel, *Adam Ferguson in the Scottish Enlightenment*, 205–12; Anna Plassart, *The Scottish Enlightenment and the French Revolution* (Cambridge, 2015), 134–5.

⁹⁵William Godwin to the National Convention of France, 26 Jan. 1793, in William Godwin, *The Letters of William Godwin*, 2 vols., ed. Pamela Clemit (Oxford, 2011–14), 1: 76.

⁹⁶Kenneth R. Johnston, *Unusual Suspects: Pitt’s Reign of Alarm and the Lost Generation of the 1790s* (Oxford, 2013).

⁹⁷Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 268. The expressions in this part were slightly toned down in subsequent editions: Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice: Variants*, 244.

⁹⁸Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 277–8.

⁹⁹*Ibid.*, 294.

¹⁰⁰*Ibid.*, 271–6.

well as “public inspection and censorship,” could work at the level of neighborhood communities.¹⁰¹

All of the above discussion was fruitless unless one could establish and maintain a democracy in modern Europe. Among the handful of *philosophes* in favor of the institution of republican or even democratic governments in the eighteenth century, the most popular means of implementing them was “representation.” An endless list of commentators from the second half of the eighteenth century can be produced on the question of political representation. In England, along with John Cartwright and Macaulay,¹⁰² Paine had been an outspoken advocate of representation “ingrafted upon” the Athenian kind of democracy. In Part II of *Rights of Man* (1792) he claimed that combining representation with democracy would ensure the exclusion of both “the ignorance and insecurity of the hereditary mode, and the inconvenience of the simple democracy.” He expected to see, to borrow Nadia Urbinati’s expression, “a perfection of democracy.”¹⁰³ Godwin, for his part, endorsed the idea of representation. His concept of representation, though designed less to check than to aid democracy, involved free rather than imperative mandate. Delegation, “an act which has for its object the general good,” was grounded upon the expectation that delegates were “more likely from talents or leisure to perform the function [of representatives] in the most eligible manner.”¹⁰⁴ Thus for Godwin the aim of representation was not to strictly relay the sovereignty of the people to a national assembly but to ascertain that important decisions concerning the political community were made, after ample discussion, by “persons of superior education and wisdom.”¹⁰⁵ Godwin was in fact hereby approving what Claeys considered him to have rejected, namely “the elective system of representation” and “the democratic process.”¹⁰⁶ Representatives, on Godwin’s account, were “authorised upon certain occasions to act on [the constituents’] part, in the same manner as an unlearned parent delegates his authority over his child to a preceptor of greater accomplishments than himself.” They were, in sum, expected to provide intelligent guidance to the less enlightened population.¹⁰⁷

Eighteenth-century discussion of political representation contained much apprehension about the possibility of the delegates’ usurpation of constituent power.¹⁰⁸ In

¹⁰¹ Ibid., 269; Kramnick, “On Anarchism and the Real World,” 118–19.

¹⁰² Macaulay, *Loose Remarks*; John Cartwright, *Take Your Choice! Representation and Respect, Imposition and Contempt; Annual Parliaments and Liberty, Long Parliaments and Slavery* (London, 1776).

¹⁰³ Paine, *Rights of Man, Part II*, 33; Nadia Urbinati, *Representative Democracy: Principles and Genealogy* (Chicago, 2006), 169; Hobson, “Revolution, Representation and the Foundations of Modern Democracy.”

¹⁰⁴ Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 92.

¹⁰⁵ Ibid., 270.

¹⁰⁶ Claeys, “William Godwin’s Critique,” 259–60.

¹⁰⁷ Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 270. Gregory Claeys evaluates that this element was “very close to being a statement of Godwin’s general theory of justice.” For an account of Godwin’s ideas of virtue, republicanism and democracy in a close association with his “Dissenting background,” see Claeys, “William Godwin’s Critique.”

¹⁰⁸ Katlyn Marie Carter, *Democracy in Darkness: Secrecy and Transparency in the Age of Revolutions* (New Haven, 2023).

the 1790s French theorists of “representative democracy” advocated a form of electoral “recall” so that the elected representatives were constantly held in check by the people whose “sovereignty” should never be alienated. If a good balance between the electors and the elected could be found, it was argued, a veritable system of representative government would avoid at once the “anarchy of the many” and the “tyranny of the few.”¹⁰⁹ Godwin summed up this tension as follows: “by this happy expedient we secure many of the pretended benefits of aristocracy, as well as the real benefits of democracy.” However, his approval of representation was predicated on a resolutely democratic condition that the elector must stay alert “in all his political concerns” and hold back for himself “his censorial power over his representative.” Most of all, in case the representative fails to persuade the elector over to his opinion, the elector must be willing and “accustomed” to revoke his representative’s authority and elect another in his place.¹¹⁰

This was entirely intelligible to Godwin’s contemporaries, for whom the notion of democracy primarily evoked a political structure more akin to that of ancient Athens than to that of modern commercial and parliamentary polities. Within the framework of Godwin’s era that contrasted democracy with representative government, “representative democracy” differed markedly from modern republicanism. The conflict between the terms “democracy” and “representation” was thus far more explicit in the political languages of the 1790s than it is today. This point is insufficiently considered in the argument made by Claeys about Godwin’s supposed rejection of “representative democracy,” in which Claeys finds an anticipation of “radical” criticisms of modern republicanism “which would later become integral elements of socialist theory.”¹¹¹ The difficulty with this view lies in the fact that the notion of representative democracy was regarded as far more “radical” in the 1790s than it would become in the nineteenth century. In this context, the key is to move beyond Claeys and point out that Godwin was not merely rejecting representative democracy in favor of ancient republicanism; rather, he was grappling with the predicament of a modern political philosopher who was resolved to support democracy with representation, while remaining acutely aware of the many defects that such a combination could produce. Even as he accorded representation the role of checking the potentially pernicious characters of democracy, the elements of “representation” and those of “democracy” were contradicting each other: the talented and enlightened few should guide the many, but then the many could and should step in to impose their will on the few. This was a puzzle not to be solved until one either (1) gave up on improvement and settled for political tutelage of the entire population by representative assemblies or (2) brought the diffusion of enlightenment to a level at which the majority (but not all) of population could discern correct judgments from incorrect ones.

On this point, Godwin made a significant revision in the third edition of *Enquiry* (1798) and stated his position more clearly. To begin with, as an antidote to ancient

¹⁰⁹ *Journal des hommes libres* (Paris), 3 floréal, an IV and 5, 21 and 30 messidor, an VII (22 April 1796, 23 June 1799, 9 July 1799, 18 July 1799); Urbinati, *Representative Democracy*; Kim, “Pierre-Antoine Antonelle,” 352.

¹¹⁰ Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 270.

¹¹¹ Claeys, “William Godwin’s Critique,” 255–62.

republicanism, he affirmed that the modern institution of representation could counteract the “defects” of popular assemblies such as those in ancient “Athens and Rome.” For him, however, representation was “necessarily imperfect” in that it “aggravated” the problem underlying all governments by removing “the power of making regulations one step further from the people whose lot it is to obey them.” The price to pay for the representative government’s function of refining democracy was the violation of the sanctity of individual judgment, a violation that Godwin was not willing to tolerate for long. Thus, even if the design of representative government incorporating democratic traits was “a palliative for certain evils,” it was crucial never to lose sight of the fact that it was “not a remedy so excellent or complete, as should authorise us to rest in it, as the highest improvement of which the social order is capable.” The solution, in the end, lay in the perfection of the human mind, not the perfection of the representative mechanism. Godwin’s time-regime made his ideas of political representation fundamentally different from those of Paine and many other radicals of his day: for Godwin the combination of democracy and representation was a temporary treatment, although it was the best option available at the current point of his time-regime.¹¹²

Conclusion

This article has shown that one needs to pay close attention to the question of time in order to make sense of Godwin’s political thought regarding anarchy and democracy. While his defense of “democracy” and Athens had elements in common with ideas proposed by Paine and Macaulay, who dared speak in support of the ancient polis, his views on the political machine of “representation” differed from those of other radicals in several respects. This was because Godwin’s vision of human perfection in the future made his perception of the place of democracy in the time-regime differ from the views of his contemporaries.

Though Godwin reserved some points of disagreement with Rousseau and regarded himself as possessing an intellect superior to that of Paine, and though he had many misgivings about ultraradicals such as Robespierre, he still held *philosophes* and reformers in general in respect. While discussing the price to be paid for speaking the truth in public in 1791, he mentioned the case of Paine favorably as proof that *parrhesia* was worth “stand[ing] in the breach.” In his eyes, “the period of sacrifices” was over for Paine, who had “secured to himself the gratitude of ages.”¹¹³ In late September 1793, after the Law of Suspects was decreed, Godwin could still write in the face of the quasi-unanimous denunciation in Britain of Robespierre and the Jacobins, “Do not exclaim so bitterly upon Robespierre! I, like you, will weep over his errors; but I must still

¹¹² Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice: Variants*, 244–5.

¹¹³ William Godwin to Richard Brinsley Sheridan, 29 April 1791, in Godwin, *The Letters of William Godwin*, 1: 58. Later in 1801, Godwin was to become “puzzled,” perhaps in a pleasant way, that his “name is held in great veneration” in America whereas “Thomas Paine has to a great degree lost his credit there, by his extreme democratical principles, and still more by his infidelity.” William Godwin to Alex Robson, 16 Sept. 1801, in Godwin, *The Letters of William Godwin*, 2: 235.

continue to regard him as an eminent benefactor of mankind.”¹¹⁴ Years later, severely criticizing James Mackintosh for his *Discourse on the Study of the Law of Nature and Nations* (1799), which was regarded as a disavowal of his former reformist inclivities, Godwin angrily asserted that “Rousseau, Turgot or Condorcet” should not be labelled “promulgators of absurd and monstrous systems” and that they were as “pure and philanthropical” as “Grotius, Puffendorf [*sic*], Wolf, Burlamaqui or Vattel.”¹¹⁵ Another fact to note is that Godwin, notwithstanding his aversion to “revolutions,” had celebrated the American and the French revolutions in the first edition of *Enquiry* as having been well prepared by “a general concert of all orders” rather than as stir-ups of demagogues or divisions within the nation such as had happened in the case of “the resistance against our Charles the First.” For him the cause of this difference between the revolutions of the seventeenth and the eighteenth centuries lay in the Enlightenment that had progressed for more than a century in between, during which “Sydney and Locke and Montesquieu and Rousseau” and their “philosophy had already developed some of the great principles of political truth.”¹¹⁶

Godwin thus believed in the power of the Republic of Letters. The prospect of pure-hearted luminaries working for human improvement was the source of hope for him, as it was for Condorcet and many others. But Godwin was no impractical dreamer; he knew very well that “where there is a government, there must be a will superseding that of individuals.”¹¹⁷ Among the multiple modes of determining the dominant will from the dominated will, Godwin considered democracy to be at once the best government and the least evil one. At present, democracy was a better choice than monarchy or aristocracy in that it encouraged reason and dignity, while it did not necessarily offer a specific transition mechanism to a future of enlightened anarchists. Even the question of how to proceed to democracy was not answered, except, again, for the hope that enlightenment could prevail in the future.

Moving from the present and the near future to a much longer view of humanity’s possible future, democratic government appeared as an evil in that it was a form of collective coercion upon individual judgments and actions. Given the indefinite scope of human perfectibility, coercion was to be deemed an unfortunate nature of government, the perennial job of which seemed to be “enslaving mankind.” During the long course of history, political systems inevitably generated “bloodshed, violence and murder.” “By the long duration of their wars,” the Romans were “to be ranked among the foremost destroyers of the human species.” The rise of states by means of war was followed by war-inflicted decline: the Romans “suffered the penalty of their iniquitous deeds; and the world was vexed for three hundred years by the irruptions of Goths, Vandals, Ostrogoths, Huns, and innumerable hordes of barbarians.” The same applied to France, Austria, Prussia, and England.¹¹⁸ History

¹¹⁴William Godwin to Alexander Jardine, 25–9 Sept. 1793, in Godwin, *The Letters of William Godwin*, 1: 84–5.

¹¹⁵William Godwin to James Mackintosh, 27 Jan. 1799, in Godwin, *The Letters of William Godwin*, 2: 67.

¹¹⁶Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 116.

¹¹⁷*Ibid.*, 92.

¹¹⁸*Ibid.*, 4–7.

had been staging time and again the grim scene in which “men deliberately destroy each other by thousands without any resentment against or even knowledge of each other.”¹¹⁹

In assessing Godwin’s shifting evaluations of democracy, the time-regime of this shift has been more or less overlooked in existing studies, including John Clark’s incisive book, on the perceived tension between Godwin’s conception of democracy as a form of government preferable to monarchy or aristocracy and his deep anxieties about the coercive power of political institutions over individual judgment. Precisely at this point, the “time-regime” perspective allows us to move beyond the theoretical dilemma of choosing between a participatory yet coercive democratic government, on the one hand, and a decentralized anarchy grounded in enlightened individual judgment, on the other—a dilemma that Godwin himself does not appear to have really confronted, if only because it did not arise within the framework of his time-regime.¹²⁰

Godwin may have despaired, like Edward Gibbon and others, at the French Republic’s wars over Europe after Thermidor, since the prospects for democracy and reform seemed to grow increasingly dim as the turn of the century approached.¹²¹ As yet, however, we have no hard proof of Godwin’s renunciation of the hopes of 1789. In 1793, at least, war seemed to him an evil of the *present*, possibly to disappear in the enlightened *future*. Condorcet had argued that on certain conditions the larger number of people participating in a case meant a larger probability of reaching the “correct” judgment. This argument was based on mathematical demonstrations, which served to support his approval of democracy as a political form and election as its working mechanism.¹²² An optimism of this kind was inscribed on Godwin’s time-regime, an optimism that anticipated a future in which the “reasonings of one wise man [would] be as effectual as those of twelve” and the “competence of one individual to instruct his neighbours [would] be a matter of sufficient notoriety, without the formality of an election.” When such time arrived it would surely be “one of the most memorable stages of human improvement,” one which would still be furthered because human capacity for perfectibility was infinite. Until that day, for Godwin, mankind’s best interim measure at hand was democracy.¹²³

¹¹⁹Ibid., 279.

¹²⁰Clark, *The Philosophical Anarchism of William Godwin*, 175–87.

¹²¹Richard Whatmore, *The End of Enlightenment: Empire, Commerce, Crisis* (London, 2023).

¹²²Duncan Black, *The Theory of Committees and Elections* (Cambridge, 1958), 163–78; Gilles-Gaston Granger, *La mathématique sociale du marquis de Condorcet* (Paris, 1989), 20–27, 42–3, 94–136; Kim, “Condorcet and the Viability of Democracy,” 189.

¹²³Godwin, *An Enquiry Concerning Political Justice*, 311. After all, it is interesting to note the similarity between the end goal in the time-regime of Godwin’s *Enquiry* and Johann Gottlieb Fichte’s statement about government in 1794–5: “The goal of all government is to make government superfluous. Though the time has certainly not yet come, nor do I know how many myriads or myriads of myriads of years it may take ... there will certainly be a point in the a priori foreordained career of the human species when all civic bonds will become superfluous. This is that point when reason, rather than strength or cunning will be universally recognized as the highest court of appeal. I say ‘be recognized’ because even then men will still make mistakes and injure their fellowmen thereby. All they will then require is the goodwill to allow themselves

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to be convinced that they have erred and, when they are convinced of this, to recant their errors and make amends for the damages.” Johann Gottlieb Fichte, *Early Philosophical Writings*, ed. Daniel Breazeale (Ithaca, 1988), 156–7; Isaac Nakhimovsky, *The Closed Commercial State: Perpetual Peace and Commercial Society from Rousseau to Fichte* (Princeton, 2011), 20.

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